CASE STUDY

Tomorrow's AI Champions Training Program

Amity School District, Oregon

40 Educators | 4 Modules | 5 Hours | 2 Cohorts

How a rural Oregon school district transformed educator confidence in AI — from hesitation to hands-on integration.

Delivered by TomoClub | August 2025

Executive Summary

In August 2025, Amity School District — a rural K–12 district in Amity, Oregon serving 756 students — partnered with TomoClub to deliver the “Tomorrow’s AI Champions” professional development program. Led by Superintendent Jeff Clark, the district made a proactive decision to invest in AI literacy for its entire teaching staff rather than wait for state mandates or react to the challenges AI was already presenting in classrooms.

TomoClub is a U.S.-based AI professional development provider built by leaders who understand schools — its advisory team includes former superintendents (Debbie Brockett of McMinnville and Clark County School Districts; Melvin Brown of Montgomery, Alabama), active superintendents (Al Lewis of Glassboro Public Schools), and clinical psychologists specializing in education. The organization has delivered AI training to districts across multiple states, and its programs are designed to be tool-agnostic, survey-personalized, and focused on the literacy that outlasts any individual platform.

The program trained 40 educators across two cohorts in a 2 intensive day of four modules spanning 5 hours. The results were immediate and measurable: 93% of participants reported stronger understanding of AI in education after the training, educator confidence in using AI tools rose from a pre-training baseline where 64% had only basic or no AI understanding to a post-training outcome where 87% rated themselves confident in using AI tools. Educators went from associating AI primarily with "cheating" to actively planning how to use it for differentiated lesson plans, inclusive assessments, and time-saving workflows.

This case study documents the district context, training design, survey data, and measurable outcomes — providing a replicable model for school leaders seeking to bring AI professional development to their own districts.

> *“Thanks for being here. My teachers and our students will benefit from this PD.”*
> — Jeff Clark, Superintendent, Amity School District (via pre-survey remarks)

Key Results at a Glance

93% Reported Stronger AI Understanding	**87%** Confident Using AI Tools (Post)	**100%** Plan to Apply AI Within 3 Months
40 Educators Trained	**4** Modules Delivered	**20+** Subjects Represented

District Profile

Amity School District is a small, rural public school district located at 807 S Trade Street, Amity, Oregon 97101. The district serves a community rooted in agriculture and small-town values, where educators often wear multiple hats and resources are more limited compared to urban and suburban counterparts.

At a Glance

District Superintendent	Jeff Clark
Location	Amity, Oregon (rural)
Educators Trained	40 across 2 cohorts (HS and Middle School)
Average Teaching Experience	13.7 years (range: 0–31 years)
Subjects Covered	ELA, Math, Science, Social Studies, PE/Health, Art, Music, Spanish, SPED, ELL, STEM, CTE, Agriculture, Wood Shop, Administration
IT Lead	Jerry Compton

This diversity of subject areas and experience levels is significant: the training had to work for a first-year science teacher, a 31-year social studies veteran, a wood shop instructor, and a middle school principal — all in the same room. It is precisely this kind of challenge that makes the results meaningful for other district leaders.

The Challenge

Before the training, TomoClub conducted a comprehensive AI Readiness Survey of 25 educators. The data revealed a teaching staff that was cautious, lightly experienced with AI, and deeply concerned about student misuse — but also genuinely curious about the possibilities.

Pre-Training AI Understanding

Self-Reported AI Understanding	Count	%
I've heard of it but don't understand it	3	12%
I have a basic understanding	13	52%
I have a good working knowledge	7	28%
I'm very knowledgeable about AI	2	8%

The takeaway: 64% of educators entered the training with only basic or no understanding of AI. Only 8% considered themselves very knowledgeable. Most had heard the buzzwords but lacked the practical skills to leverage AI in their workflows.

AI Usage Before Training

While most educators had at least tried an AI tool, their usage was shallow. Only 16% used AI regularly. A full 40% had either never used it or tried it just once or twice. ChatGPT was the dominant tool (used by 21 of 25 respondents), followed by Grammarly (12), and Canva Magic Tools (8). Most usage was limited to personal productivity tasks like email drafting — not instructional design or assessment.

The Dominant Concern: Student Cheating

When asked about their biggest concerns, the word "cheating" appeared more than any other theme in the open-ended responses. Educators expressed deep anxiety about academic integrity, loss of critical thinking skills, and student over-reliance on AI. Many explicitly associated AI with plagiarism before anything else.

> *"Many/most students already struggle with literacy and there are studies that link the use of AI to decreased critical thinking skills."*
>
> — Lena Morrow, Middle School ELA Teacher

> *"What does pervasive AI use say about the culture we have created in our schools?"*
>
> — Nate Ninteman, HS Math Teacher

Importantly, only 4% of educators believed AI would significantly reduce their workload, while 24% were unsure it would have any impact at all. The dominant sentiment was cautious pragmatism rather than enthusiasm.

The Cost of Doing Nothing

For school leaders weighing whether AI professional development is worth the investment, it helps to consider what happens without it. The pre-survey data from Amity paints a clear picture of the risks districts face when they delay.

Teacher Time and Burnout

Amity educators reported spending significant time on tasks AI can accelerate: lesson planning, creating differentiated materials, drafting parent communications, building assessments, and grading. These are hours that come at the expense of direct student interaction — the work that actually drew most teachers to the profession. When 52% of a staff describes their AI understanding as "basic," those hours aren't being reclaimed. According to TomoClub's cross-district data, educators who complete the program report saving 8+ hours per week on routine tasks — time that flows directly back into student-facing work.

The Widening Equity Gap

As the training's Module 1 emphasized, the gap between "AI-haves" and "AI-have-nots" is becoming the defining equity challenge in education. Students in districts where teachers understand AI are getting differentiated instruction, adaptive assessments, and personalized feedback. Students in districts that delay get none of this. The longer a district waits, the wider the gap grows — and rural districts like Amity are especially vulnerable because they can't afford to lose ground.

Unchecked Student AI Use

Perhaps the most urgent cost of inaction: students are already using AI whether teachers are prepared or not. Before the training, Amity educators described a landscape where students were using ChatGPT for homework and papers with no framework for responsible use. Without trained teachers setting norms, creating AI-integrated assignments, and teaching citation practices, student AI use defaults to the path of least resistance — which is exactly the "cheating" problem that 20% of surveyed educators cited as their top concern.

> **The question for school leaders is not "Can we afford AI professional development?" It's "Can we afford the teacher burnout, the equity gaps, and the unchecked student AI use that comes from doing nothing?"**

The Solution: Tomorrow's AI Champions Program

TomoClub designed a four-module, 5-hour professional development program specifically calibrated to Amity's needs. Rather than delivering generic AI training, the curriculum was built around the pre-survey data — directly addressing the cheating concerns, the low confidence levels, and the practical reality of a staff that spans wood shop to AP English.

Program Architecture

Module	Title	Focus
1	**Awareness**	AI terminology, landscape, educator roles in AI era, human superpowers identification
2	**Efficiency**	Smart prompting (Prompt Generator), AI tools for lesson planning, presentations, audio, video; building personal AI toolkits

3	**Ethics**	Bias and hallucination testing, academic integrity, copyright, data privacy (FERPA), digital citizenship, AI literacy curriculum design
4	**Assessment &Personalisation**	Differentiated lesson plans, inclusive assessments, adaptive rubrics, AI-enhanced feedback, reimagining assignments, classroom AI policy creation

Design Principles

Hands-On from Minute One. Every module included breakout room activities where educators built real outputs — lesson plans, differentiated assessments, AI toolkits — using their own subject matter. This was not a lecture series; educators left with artifacts they could use the next day.

Address the Elephant in the Room. Module 3 (Ethics) was placed at the center of the program deliberately. Instead of dismissing cheating concerns, the training tackled them head-on with activities like bias-testing prompts in Gemini, a "Two Truths and AI" game, and frameworks for reimagining assignments rather than policing them.

Practical Tool Exposure. TomoClub coordinated with IT Lead Jerry Compton to pre-verify access to 10 AI tools on the district network, including ChatGPT, Gemini, NotebookLM, Napkin AI, and ElevenLabs. Educators could explore tools in real time without running into access barriers.

The "Prompt of Prompts" Framework. Rather than teaching individual prompts, the training taught educators a universal meta-prompt — a saved prompt that generates other prompts. This gave every educator, regardless of subject, a repeatable system they could apply independently.

Mid-Session Pulse Check

After Modules 1 and 2 (Awareness and Efficiency), TomoClub collected an exit ticket from 15 educators to gauge real-time sentiment. The session scored an average of 4.4 out of 5.

The qualitative responses revealed a staff in productive tension — excited by the tools but processing a high volume of new information.

> *"I can make a legit lesson plan in no time!"*
> — Jill Whitehead, HS PE/Health Teacher, 23 years experience

> *"Overwhelmed but enlightened. The master prompt was really helpful and I will use that to create lesson plans and syllabi."*
> — Andrea Wilburn, HS Art Teacher

> *"I still have to generate the content basics, but AI can help me learn more and present better. It is a learning tool for me, as well as my students."*

— Kimi Barnett, HS ELA Teacher, 26 years experience

How TomoClub Adapted in Real Time

Rather than ignoring this signal, TomoClub made immediate adjustments to Modules 3 and 4: longer breakout room time (a direct request from multiple educators), clearer written instructions for group tasks, and a shift toward deeper exploration of fewer tools rather than broader surface-level coverage. The mid-session exit ticket is not just data collection — it is a calibration mechanism that allows the facilitator to adjust pacing for the second half.

The key insight for school leaders: productive overwhelm is different from unproductive confusion. Amity's educators were overwhelmed because they were seeing genuine possibilities for the first time. The post-training data confirms this — the same educators who reported feeling overwhelmed went on to rate the program positively and describe concrete application plans.

Post-Training Outcomes

At the conclusion of the full program, 28 educators completed the comprehensive post-training survey. The data tells a clear story of meaningful growth across every measured dimension.

Confidence Metrics (1–5 Scale)

Metric	Average	Rated 4–5	% HighConfidence
Training Value	4.45	26/28	**93%**
Confidence Using AI Tools	4.38	24/28	**87%**
Identifying AI-Suitable Tasks	4.29	23/28	**82%**
Prompt Engineering Skills	4.12	21/28	**75%**
Digital Citizenship Guidance	4.41	25/28	**89%**
Differentiated Learning with AI	4.25	22/28	**79%**

The Transformation: Before vs. After

The most telling metric is the self-reported change in AI understanding. Before the training, 64% of educators had basic or no understanding of AI. After the training:

Understanding Change	Count	%
Much stronger	10	**36%**
Stronger	16	**57%**
About the same	2	**7%**

93% of educators reported stronger AI understanding after the training, with more than a third describing the change as "much stronger." Only 2 out of 28 respondents reported no change — and notably, zero participants reported feeling less confident or more confused than before.

Mindset Shift: From "Cheating" to "Opportunity"

Perhaps the most significant outcome is qualitative. Before the training, the word most associated with AI was "cheating." After the training, educators' open-ended responses centered on lesson planning, differentiation, time savings, and responsible student use.

The shift in language reflects a fundamental reframing — from seeing AI as a threat to seeing it as an instructional partner.

What Educators Plan to Do Next

Every single respondent described a concrete plan for applying AI within the next 3 months. The most common planned applications included lesson plan creation and differentiation, using Gemini and ChatGPT for brainstorming and content creation, building presentations with Gamma, deploying Brisk Teaching for real-time student feedback, creating adaptive quizzes and assessments, and teaching students responsible AI citation practices.

> *"So many ways, but with the main goal of increasing our competence and confidence in utilizing AI."*
> — Mary Matocha, Middle School Principal

> *"I plan to spend the fall teaching the appropriate use of AI."*
> — Kimi Barnett, HS ELA Teacher

> *"I plan on distinguishing different tasks that I know I can have AI create versus tasks that are better left for me to create or finish."*
> — Frances Momberg, HS Science Teacher

> *“Establish a database of prompts to use in certain instructional situations.”*
> — Savannah Stanton, HS Wood Shop Teacher

> *“Start with AI education in the classroom — thinking about how to add AI literacy to assignments.”*
> — Lena Morrow, Middle School ELA Teacher

Return on Investment for School Leaders

AI professional development is not a luxury spend — it is an operational investment with tangible returns. Here is how the Tomorrow’s AI Champions program pays for itself.

Time Saved

Across TomoClub’s partner districts, trained educators report saving 8+ hours per week on tasks AI can accelerate: lesson planning, differentiation, assessment creation, parent communications, and grading rubrics. For a district of 40 educators, that represents roughly 320 recovered hours per week — time that flows back into student interaction, professional growth, and the human work that no AI can replace.

Teacher Burnout Reduced

The administrative burden on educators is a leading contributor to burnout and attrition. When educators describe feeling “overwhelmed” by documentation, differentiation demands, and constant email — as Amity’s pre-survey data showed — AI literacy directly addresses the root cause. Educators who know how to use AI for routine tasks report not just time savings, but a qualitative shift in their relationship to their work. As one Amity educator put it after the training: “I can make a legit lesson plan in no time!” That is the sound of burnout receding.

> *“Given the right tools, our time can be better focused towards our strengths.”*
> — Lena Morrow, Middle School ELA Teacher (pre-survey)

Student Outcomes

When teachers can generate differentiated materials in minutes rather than hours, every student gets instruction closer to their level. Amity’s training equipped educators to build inclusive assessments for gifted learners, students reading below grade level, ELL students, and students with IEPs — all from a single prompt. The downstream effect on student engagement and achievement compounds over time.

For most districts, the educator time savings alone cover the investment within the first month. The cost of doing nothing — teacher burnout, widening equity gaps, unchecked student AI use — compounds every semester.

Tools That Resonated

Educators were asked which tools they were most excited to try. The results show strong interest across a range of platforms, reflecting the training's emphasis on matching tools to specific use cases rather than promoting a single solution.

Top Tools by Educator Mentions

Tool	Educator Use Case
Gemini	Lesson planning, research, deep-research for rubric banks
Gamma	Rapid slide creation, revamping old presentations
Brisk Teaching	In-document feedback, AI plagiarism reference, Chrome extension
Otter.ai	Real-time captions for inclusive classrooms
Napkin AI	Visual mind maps from lesson plan text
NotebookLM	Organizing references, generating summaries from PDFs
ChatGPT	General brainstorming, differentiated content creation

Educator Voices

The most compelling evidence of the training's impact comes from the educators themselves. These are unedited responses from the post-training survey:

> *"I really knew nothing about AI, this was helpful."*
> — Jill Whitehead, PE/Health Teacher, 23 years experience

> *"AI tools I can use for school. The crazy technology available!"*
> — John Stearns, CTE Shop Teacher, 24 years experience

> *"Revamping some very old documents and presentations, for sure. I also appreciate the expanded understanding of AI so that I can restructure assignments to work with and around AI."*
> — Kimi Barnett, ELA Teacher, 26 years experience

> *"It was a lot more effective for me to be in a room with a group. The discussion helped concepts be clearer. Ideas were more clearly generated. I wish my whole staff could have been here."*
> — Kimi Barnett, ELA Teacher

> *"Lesson scaffolding. I plan to use it for lesson plans, idea generation, and some organizational items as well."*
> — Chastene Hansen, Social Studies Teacher

> *"Post Tomo AI Training, educators are sharing new AI tools or strategies to each other."*
> — Mary Matocha, Principal, Amity School District

Lessons for School Leaders

The Amity experience offers several actionable insights for superintendents, principals, and curriculum directors considering AI professional development for their own districts.

1. Start with a Readiness Survey. The pre-training survey directly shaped the curriculum. Knowing that 52% of staff had only basic understanding and that "cheating" was the dominant concern allowed TomoClub to address anxiety proactively.

2. Don't Avoid the Hard Conversations. Placing ethics at the center earned educator trust. When staff see that their concerns are taken seriously, they open up to the possibilities.

3. Expect Productive Overwhelm — and Plan for It. Build in a calibration mechanism (like the exit ticket) so the facilitator can adjust in real time. The educators who felt most overwhelmed at midpoint often showed the greatest growth by the end.

4. Make It Hands-On for Every Subject. A wood shop teacher and an ELA teacher have very different relationships with AI. Breakout activities let each educator apply tools to their own content.

5. Teach the Meta-Skill, Not Just the Tool. The "Prompt of Prompts" gives educators a system that outlasts any specific platform.

6. Coordinate with IT Before Day One. Pre-verifying tool access on the district network eliminated friction during live demos.

7. Rural Districts Can Lead, Not Follow. If this worked in a 756-student rural district with limited resources, it is designed to work anywhere.

Conclusion

Amity School District's "Tomorrow's AI Champions" program demonstrates that meaningful AI professional development is achievable in a single day, for an entire teaching staff, in a resource-constrained rural setting. The numbers are clear: 93% of educators left with stronger AI understanding, 87% rated themselves highly confident across key competency areas, and every respondent described a concrete plan for applying AI in their practice.

But the real story is the transformation in mindset. A staff that associated AI with cheating walked out planning differentiated lesson plans, inclusive assessments, and responsible digital citizenship curricula. That shift — from fear to informed confidence — is the foundation that every school district needs before it can integrate AI meaningfully into instruction.

As one educator put it: ***"AI won't replace teachers, but teachers who use AI wisely will be the ones who prepare students for tomorrow."***

Your Next Step: A 30-Minute Discovery Call

Every district's AI journey starts with a conversation, not a contract. TomoClub offers a complimentary 30-minute discovery call where we review your district's current landscape, share relevant data from comparable districts, and help you determine whether structured AI PD is the right move — with zero obligation.

What you get from the call alone (even if you go no further): a clear picture of where your staff stands relative to national benchmarks, 2–3 quick wins your educators can implement immediately, and a framework for thinking about AI policy at the district level.

If You Decide to Move Forward

Step 1: AI Readiness Survey. We deploy a customized survey to your educators so the training content is calibrated to their actual starting point — not assumptions.

Step 2: Customized Proposal. You receive a detailed proposal with scope, schedule, and pricing tailored to your district.

Step 3: District Rollout. Seamless onboarding, IT coordination for tool access, and full delivery. All educators receive PD certificates.

Step 4: Ongoing Support. Your educators join TomoClub's Slack community, receive weekly AI updates filtered for schools, access a centralized resource library, and get a monthly AI pedagogy newsletter. This is not a one-off session — it's a complete support system.

Schedule Your Free Discovery Call

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About TomoClub

TomoClub partners with school districts across the United States to deliver AI professional development that is data-driven, hands-on, and designed for the realities of K–12 education. Built by leaders who understand schools — including former superintendents, active superintendents, clinical psychologists, and educators — TomoClub's programs are tool-agnostic, survey-personalized, and focused on building the literacy that outlasts any individual platform.